

Workshop Session 3 | Building Regional Ocean Partnerships

Discussion Paper

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The aim of this background paper is to provide a starting point for discussions on the development of regional ocean partnerships for implementation of SDG14 and the broader 2030 Agenda. The paper provides an introduction to the place of regional initiatives in the overall international ocean governance framework and offers some guidance for discussion, structured around three key themes: 1. Regional implementation of SDG14; 2. Development of regional ocean partnerships; and 3. Platforms to facilitate and enhance regional cooperation and collaboration.

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Context

Ocean issues are an integral part of the global sustainable development agenda and are the subject of a dedicated Sustainable Development Goal (SDG): to “conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development” (SDG14, see Annex 1). A wide range of commitments has been made for ocean sustainability¹ and processes are underway to further strengthen the international legal framework.²

The responsibility for achieving the SDGs lies with UN member States, but the transboundary nature of marine resources and threats to the marine environment require States to work together. Fish stocks, pollution, and marine ecosystems do not respect national boundaries, thus an ecosystem-based management (EBM) approach is necessary (see Annex 3). Regional ocean governance can enable the cross-sectoral and transboundary cooperation needed to implement EBM. At the same time, regional initiatives can support national action and progress towards global goals. Regional governance can therefore play a key complementary role, acting as both a catalyst for action and an intermediary between high-level global policy and national implementation.

Regional governance has long been a crucial part of the overall legal and policy framework for the ocean. The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS, 1982) encourages States to cooperate “as appropriate, on a regional basis, directly or through competent international organisations for the protection and preservation of the marine environment, taking into account characteristic regional features” (Article 197).

The importance of regional ocean governance is also stressed in other global agreements and policy processes,³ while a number of key forums have recently highlighted its role in implementing the SDGs. For example, the Call for Action resulting from the UN Ocean Conference (June 2017) states:⁴

We stress the need for an integrated, interdisciplinary and cross-sectoral approach as well as enhanced cooperation, coordination, and policy coherence, at all levels. We emphasise the critical importance of effective partnerships enabling collective action and reaffirm our commitment to the implementation of Goal 14 with the full participation of all relevant stakeholders.

There is now an undeniable momentum for ocean action: increased understanding of the urgency of ocean issues has driven unprecedented political will and resulted in scores of concrete and ambitious commitments. This represents an opportunity to strengthen governance systems, close legal and institutional gaps, and improve cooperation and collaboration. With adequate support and investment, regional ocean governance initiatives and partnerships can play a pivotal role in translating words and commitments into concrete actions for ocean sustainability.

¹ E.g. 1406 voluntary commitments and partnerships for ocean sustainability were announced at the UN Ocean Conference; 437 commitments and €7.2 billion in financial pledges were made at the 2017 Our Ocean conference. See <https://www.oceanconference.un.org/commitments> and <https://www.ourocean2017.org/our-ocean-commitments> respectively.

² Including by negotiating a new international legally binding instrument for the conservation and sustainable use of marine biodiversity in areas beyond national jurisdiction, and the development of a Mining Code by the International Seabed Authority.

³ Including: the UN Fish Stocks Agreement (UNFSA); Agenda 21 (adopted at the UN Conference on Environment and Development, Rio de Janeiro, 1992); the Strategic Plan for Biodiversity 2011-2020 and the Aichi Biodiversity Targets (2010) adopted under the auspices of the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD); and “The Future We Want” outcome document from Rio+20 (2012).

⁴ <https://www.oceanconference.un.org/callforaction/>.

1 Regional implementation of SDG14

Regional organisations and mechanisms have proved to be effective in fostering marine conservation and sustainable ocean management.⁵ Regional initiatives are a cornerstone of marine EBM, as they can be developed and implemented at appropriate ecosystem scales,⁶ and they have frequently succeeded in securing strong commitments and action in pursuit of global policy goals. Inclusive initiatives can facilitate cooperation among national and local stakeholders, foster peer-to-peer learning, and ensure the involvement of civil society in decision-making processes. This allows policy and practice to be informed by the ecological, economic, political, and cultural characteristics of marine regions.

However, ocean governance organisations and mechanisms face many challenges, and regional efforts are no exception. Regional organisations often have limited human and financial resources, yet sustainable, long-term financing can be elusive. Unclear or weak legal frameworks can further complicate matters, especially where different actors in a region have overlapping interests or mandates. In such cases, regional organisations may have limited room for manoeuvre. Coordination and cooperation across a diverse range of national contexts, interests, and capacities are at the heart of regional ocean governance efforts, but even successful initiatives can be derailed by political changes or institutional restructuring.

Facilitating effective regional cooperation in the face of such challenges can be labour-intensive and time-consuming, limiting the ability of regional initiatives to support ambitious national action and slowing progress towards EBM. These challenges can also be discouraging, impeding leadership and active engagement, especially where resources are limited. Strong regional governance and EBM are essential to ensuring that ocean sustainability targets are met, and the 2030 Agenda provides the opportunity to redouble support for regional efforts.

A recent report of the Partnership for Regional Ocean Governance (PROG – see below) delivered four key messages regarding the role regional ocean governance initiatives can play:⁷

1. Regional cooperation is essential for ocean sustainability

Regional approaches to ocean governance make it possible for States and stakeholders to cooperate at an ecosystem scale and work together across sectors and national boundaries.

2. Most of the SDG14 targets can be addressed through regional initiatives

Regional approaches and instruments can add value to global and national action for most of the SDG14 targets, with particular relevance in the areas of marine pollution, sustainable ocean management, fisheries, conservation, and economic benefits for Small Island Developing States and Least Developed Countries.

3. Regional ocean governance is a driver for the development of integrated approaches

Regional approaches can help advance ocean governance by bringing all relevant actors together, taking the interdependencies among SDG14 targets into account, and providing co-benefits for the other SDGs.

4. Regional ocean governance efforts require greater support to overcome gaps and institutional weaknesses

Regional cooperation is key to the success of SDG14 and the 2030 Agenda, and should be further strengthened, including through capacity building and the development of regional partnerships.

⁵ See PROG, Partnering for a Sustainable Ocean: The Role of Regional Ocean Governance in Implementing SDG14 (2017). http://www.prog-ocean.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/03/PROG_Partnering-for-a-Sustainable-Ocean_Report.pdf.

⁶ Ongoing initiatives and organisations at such scales include, for example: Helcom in the Baltic Sea; OSPAR in the Northeast Atlantic; and the Coral Triangle Initiative.

⁷ Partnering for a Sustainable Ocean (2017), note 5.

2 Building regional ocean partnerships

The SDGs provide a global framework for governments, the private sector, civil society and other actors (e.g. donors and development cooperation agencies) to work together. SDG 17 underscores the importance of inclusive partnerships, innovative approaches, and the sharing of lessons learned at the national level. In addition to targets and indicators on overarching global issues such as finance, technology and trade, SDG17 calls on the global community to:

- *Enhance the global partnership for sustainable development, complemented by multi-stakeholder partnerships that mobilize and share knowledge, expertise, technology and financial resources, to support the achievement of the sustainable development goals in all countries, in particular developing countries; and*
- *Encourage and promote effective public, public-private and civil society partnerships...*

Likewise, the UN Ocean Conference Call for Action notes the need to:⁸

Strengthen and promote effective and transparent multi-stakeholder partnerships, including public-private partnerships, by enhancing engagement of governments with global, regional and sub-regional bodies and programmes, the scientific community, the private sector, donor community, non-governmental organisations, community groups, academic institutions, and other relevant actors.

Partnership is especially important for implementing the SDGs for the ocean and coasts. The overall framework for ocean governance is notoriously fragmented, and is often lamented as being less than the sum of its parts. A wide range of bodies and mechanisms play a role in governing the ocean, but relevant regional, sectoral and global organisations do not have mandates covering the full set of SDG 14 targets. In addition, many pressures and impacts come from terrestrial or atmospheric sources, and therefore generally lie beyond the mandates and capacities of ocean governance institutions.

There are many types of partnership (e.g. private-public, multi-stakeholder, cross sectoral) and various ways to differentiate between them (purpose, structure, governance-level). It is therefore important to consider what kind of partnership is appropriate for specific contexts and objectives. The recommendations from the Regional Ocean Governance Day at the 2017 UN Ocean Conference could provide a starting point for developing partnerships in the ocean context.⁹ These recommendations noted that: the focus should be on integrated implementation through enhanced cross-sectoral cooperation; there is a need for a better facilitation of exchange and learning processes between regions (e.g. through twinning arrangements or a dedicated forum); and that an improved link is needed to connect regional and global processes (e.g. through a nested approach of regional assessments within a global review of the state of the world ocean).

Building on these recommendations, and cognisant of the need to address the aforementioned gaps in ocean governance, partnerships for the ocean could be:

⁸ <https://www.oceanconference.un.org/commitments>.

⁹ Reported to the Partnership Dialogue on Law of the Sea at the UN Ocean Conference (June 2017). For further information about this event, see: https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/15328Concept_and_Agenda.pdf.

- Cross-sectoral and multi-stakeholder, thereby bringing enhanced cooperation and coherence to the fragmented governance framework;
- Regional, in order to address ecosystem-scale challenges and move towards EBM, while also accounting for associated political, economic and social characteristics.

Such cross-sectoral and multi-stakeholder regional ocean partnerships could:

- Provide platforms for a diverse range of actors to collaborate in the SDG implementation, bringing together States, regional organisations and mechanisms, and a broad spectrum of stakeholders;
- Develop and implement concrete measures, e.g.: institutional capacity-building; the development of regional and ecosystem-specific targets; regionally coordinated indicators and reporting processes; strategies to address cross-cutting challenges;
- Provide mechanisms through which States and competent organisations could cooperate towards the harmonised implementation of measures to address sustainability challenges, in particular where these are subject to different legal regimes or call for cross-cutting action (e.g. ocean acidification and overfishing); and
- Contribute to the development of the conditions necessary for effective interplay between relevant actors (i.e. “non-hierarchical organizations operating in sync based on a common purpose and set of principles”)¹⁰.

Momentum and political will for such partnerships is already growing. To take just one recent example, the Contracting Parties of the Nairobi Convention, working with a broad range of partners, have committed to establishing a regional SDG14 partnership for the Western Indian Ocean (WIO)¹¹ that aims to: “reduce marine pollution, demonstrate and enhance ocean governance and sustainably manage critical coastal and marine ecosystems for a prosperous Western Indian Ocean”.

In many cases, the necessary instruments to form such partnerships are readily available. The format of these partnerships should be tailored to the specific needs and opportunities specific to the regional context. Regional partnerships could be implemented, for example, through regional dialogues and annual meetings of regional and sectoral ocean management organisations, together with the scientific community and stakeholders. Experience from existing regional collaboration has also shown that regular high-level regional conferences with political and societal leaders are important to generate political will and secure buy-in from key decision makers.

¹⁰ R. Mahon et al., Assessment of Governance Arrangements for the Ocean, Volume 2: Areas Beyond National Jurisdiction (Transboundary Waters Assessment Programme, 2015).

¹¹ <https://oceanconference.un.org/commitments/?id=15788>.

3 Platforms for facilitating and supporting regional ocean partnerships

Recognising both the key role regional initiatives can play in ocean governance and the considerable challenges such initiatives face, a number of platforms are being developed to support the development of regional ocean partnerships.

UN-driven initiatives

The CBD Sustainable Ocean Initiative (SOI) is a “global platform to build partnerships and enhance capacity to achieve the Aichi Biodiversity Targets related to marine and coastal biodiversity”.¹² The SOI aims to: facilitate the sharing and exchange of knowledge, information, experiences and practices; create partnerships that can provide targeted capacity-building and technical assistance; enhance communication among global policy, science and local stakeholders; monitor progress on Aichi Biodiversity Targets related to marine and coastal biodiversity; and develop partnerships among different sectors and stakeholders at local, regional and global scales; and promote flexible and diverse approaches towards the conservation and sustainable use of marine biodiversity.

The SOI has conducted a number of national and regional capacity building workshops, developed information-sharing activities, and held global meetings of SOI partners.¹³ In 2016, the SOI held a ‘Global Dialogue with Regional Seas Organizations and Regional Fisheries Bodies on Accelerating Progress Towards the Aichi Biodiversity Targets’, with a second such meeting planned for 2018. This meeting brought together Regional Seas programmes (RSPs) and Regional Fisheries Bodies (RFBs) to share lessons learned on regional-scale cooperation and scientific mechanisms and discuss initiatives to better support regional-level collaboration.¹⁴

The LME: LEARN project,¹⁵ in collaboration with UNEP and the FAO, held a similar meeting in November 2017, entitled ‘Building International Partnership to Enhance Science Based Ecosystem Approaches in support of Regional Ocean Governance in the Context of 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development’.¹⁶ The meeting aimed to: strengthen regional governance mechanisms through enhanced collaboration between Large Marine Ecosystem (LME) programmes, RSPs and RFBs; share examples of best practices of existing collaboration; propose regional partnerships that build on existing initiatives to strengthen regional ocean science and governance; identify modalities to apply science-based ecosystem approaches at regional level in support of improved ocean governance; and describe how regional institutions and projects are utilizing science and how they can support countries to implement ecosystem approaches that will contribute to the 2030 Agenda. A roadmap document will be published to propose ways to move toward closer integration.

¹² See <https://www.cbd.int/marine/doc/soi-brochure-2012-en.pdf>.

¹³ See <https://www.cbd.int/doc/meetings/mar/soiom-2014-02/official/soiom-2014-02-actionplan-en.pdf>.

¹⁴ See <https://www.cbd.int/doc/meetings/mar/soiom-2016-01/official/soiom-2016-01-outcome-en.pdf>.

¹⁵ Managed by the Intergovernmental Oceanographic Commission (IOC) of UNESCO, implemented by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and by the Global Environment Facility (GEF).

¹⁶ See <http://www.marine.iwlearn.net/capetown2017/meeting-homepage-cape-town-2017/27-28-november-2017-building-international-partnerships>.

Partnership for Regional Ocean Governance (PROG)

Following recommendations from the 2014 Potsdam Ocean Governance Workshop, the PROG was initiated to advance regional cooperation for the conservation and sustainable use of marine ecosystems and resources.¹⁷ The PROG aims to identify and promote integrated regional models for cross-sectoral ocean governance and to advance regional cooperation for the conservation and sustainable use of marine ecosystems and resources. Established as a platform at the interface of science, policy and society, the PROG focuses on fostering greater regional cooperation and increasing integration and coherence at regional and national levels.

The PROG operates and provide new knowledge on integrated ocean governance at three different levels: (1) within regions; (2) between regions; and (3) between the regional level and the global level. Thematic focus areas of the PROG are the implementation of the 2030 Agenda and the conservation of marine biodiversity in areas beyond national jurisdiction (ABNJ).

Various initiatives have been undertaken in the South East Atlantic, South East Pacific and the Western Indian Ocean, and the German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (BMZ) has supported the PROG to advance these efforts, including through a comprehensive study of the role of regional ocean governance¹⁸ and identification of regionally coordinated approaches towards SDG14 in the Western Indian Ocean and the Caribbean. In addition, the recently launched IKI Project “STRONG High Seas”¹⁹ will develop targeted regional measures to support EBM in ABNJ and facilitate exchange, both between regions and between regions and global processes.

PROG Forums

The 2016 POGW recommended the establishment of a mechanism for cooperation and exchange, both between regions and between regional initiatives and global processes. Such a mechanism would be a way to broaden the scope of existing cooperation, set up joint learning processes for complex implementation issues, and further improve stakeholder engagement. The PROG has since developed this concept and garnered support for the convening of such a forum.

At the 2017 Our Ocean Conference, the European Union and Germany announced that they will support the establishment of PROG Forums as a “cross-sectoral and cross-boundary multi-stakeholder platform for regional ocean governance by 2020”.²⁰ The PROG Forums will provide a flexible and informal platform to involve relevant stakeholders. It is intended that this platform will encourage regional and inter-regional collaboration and exchange of new knowledge, good practices and innovative solutions. The PROG Forum will be further developed in 2018, building on a

¹⁷ The PROG was initiated in 2015 by the Institute for Advanced Sustainability Studies (IASS), the Institute for Sustainable Development and International Relations (IDDRI) and TMG Think Tank for Sustainability, together with UN Environment. See <http://www.prog-ocean.org/>.

¹⁸ Partnering for a Sustainable Ocean (2017), note 5.

¹⁹ ‘Strengthening Regional Ocean Governance for the High Seas’ (STRONG High Seas) is a five-year project funded through the International Climate Initiative (IKI) of the German Federal Ministry for the Environment, Nature Conservation, Building and Nuclear Safety. See <http://www.prog-ocean.org/strong-high-seas-iki-project-launched-at-un-ocean-conference/>.

²⁰ See https://www.ourocean2017.org/sites/default/files/ooc-2017-list-of-commitments_en.pdf.

collaborative process with international partners; a first international conference of the PROG Forum will be organised in 2019 with support of the European Union and Germany.

4 Discussion points for the workshop

Regional implementation of SDG14

How could the SDG process support the implementation and further development of integrated policies at the regional scale?

How have regions taken up the SDGs, in particular SDG14? Which regional organisations are active (RSP, RFBs, regional economic organisations)?

What do regional organisations need to be able to implement these commitments?

Development of regional ocean partnerships

Are cross-sectoral and multi-stakeholder regional partnerships the appropriate type of partnership for implementation of SDG14?

What will such partnerships look like in practice? What can we learn from existing initiatives that tackle ocean issues at the regional scale?

How can we facilitate and support the development of such partnerships? What are the drivers, opportunities and challenges?

How can they be financed? What role can development cooperation play?

Platforms to facilitate and enhance regional cooperation and collaboration

How could regional collaboration platform such as the PROG Forum best support implementation of the 2030 Agenda across governance sectors and scales?

How might we facilitate cross-sectoral learning process within and between regions?

How can we encourage and support interregional collaboration and coordination processes?

Likewise between the global and regional level?

Are there distinct roles for by different initiatives in providing for different forms of cooperation?

Further reading

PROG, 'Partnering for a Sustainable Ocean: The Role of Regional Ocean Governance in Implementing SDG14' (2017). http://www.prog-ocean.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/03/PROG_Partnering-for-a-Sustainable-Ocean_Report.pdf

UN Environment, 'Moving to Strategy and Action: Regional Seas Outlook for the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals' (2017).
http://wedocs.unep.org/bitstream/handle/20.500.11822/20866/RS_SDG_outlook_covered.pdf

UN Environment, 'Realizing Integrated Regional Oceans Governance: Summary of case studies on regional cross-sectoral institutional cooperation and policy coherence' (2017).
https://wedocs.unep.org/bitstream/handle/20.500.11822/21692/realizing_integrated_reg_oceans_governance.pdf

Outcome of the Sustainable Ocean Initiative Global Dialogue with Regional Seas Organizations and Regional Fisheries Bodies on Accelerating Progress towards the Aichi Biodiversity Targets, held in Seoul from 26 to 28 September 2016 ("Seoul Outcome").
<https://www.cbd.int/doc/meetings/mar/soiom-2016-01/official/soiom-2016-01-outcome-en.pdf>

Annex 1: SDG14 targets and indicators

Target	Indicator
14.1 By 2025, prevent and significantly reduce marine pollution of all kinds, in particular from land-based activities, including marine debris and nutrient pollution	14.1.1 Index of coastal eutrophication and floating plastic debris density
14.2 By 2020, sustainably manage and protect marine and coastal ecosystems to avoid significant adverse impacts, including by strengthening their resilience, and take action for their restoration in order to achieve healthy and productive oceans	14.2.1 Proportion of national exclusive economic zones managed using ecosystem-based approaches
14.3 Minimize and address the impacts of ocean acidification, including through enhanced scientific cooperation at all levels	14.3.1 Average marine acidity (pH) measured at agreed suite of representative sampling stations
14.4 By 2020, effectively regulate harvesting and end overfishing, illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing and destructive fishing practices and implement science-based management plans, in order to restore fish stocks in the shortest time feasible, at least to levels that can produce maximum sustainable yield as determined by their biological characteristics	14.4.1 Proportion of fish stocks within biologically sustainable levels
14.5 By 2020, conserve at least 10 per cent of coastal and marine areas, consistent with national and international law and based on the best available scientific information	14.5.1 Coverage of protected areas in relation to marine areas
14.6 By 2020, prohibit certain forms of fisheries subsidies which contribute to overcapacity and overfishing, eliminate subsidies that contribute to illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing and refrain from introducing new such subsidies, recognizing that appropriate and effective special and differential treatment for developing and least developed countries should be an integral part of the World Trade Organization fisheries subsidies negotiation	14.6.1 Progress by countries in the degree of implementation of international instruments aiming to combat illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing
14.7 By 2030, increase the economic benefits to small island developing States and least developed countries from the sustainable use of marine resources, including through sustainable management of fisheries, aquaculture and tourism	14.7.1 Sustainable fisheries as a percentage of GDP in small island developing States, least developed countries and all countries
14.a Increase scientific knowledge, develop research capacity and transfer marine technology, taking into account the Intergovernmental Oceanographic Commission Criteria and Guidelines on the Transfer of Marine Technology, in order to improve ocean health and to enhance the contribution of marine biodiversity to the development of developing countries, in particular small island developing States and least developed countries	14.a.1 Proportion of total research budget allocated to research in the field of marine technology
14.b Provide access for small-scale artisanal fishers to marine resources and markets	14.b.1 Progress by countries in the degree of application of a legal/regulatory/policy/institutional framework which recognises and protects access rights for small-scale fisheries
14.c Enhance the conservation and sustainable use of oceans and their resources by implementing international law as reflected in the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, which provides the legal framework for the conservation and sustainable use of oceans and their resources, as recalled in paragraph 158 of "The future we want"	14.c.1 Number of countries making progress in ratifying, accepting and implementing through legal, policy and institutional frameworks, ocean-related instruments that implement international law, as reflected in the United Nation Convention on the Law of the Sea, for the conservation and sustainable use of the oceans and their resources

Annex 2: Key dates for the implementation of SDG14

September 2015: Adoption of 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development

January 2016: UN publishes First World Ocean Assessment

March 2016: UNEP, Italy and Partners agree on Rome call to Action on SDG Target 14.5

July 2016: High Level Political Forum review on “Ensuring that no one is left behind” and Voluntary Reviews by 22 Member States

September 2016: Our Ocean conference in Washington, D.C.

5-9 June 2017: The UN Ocean Conference to support the implementation of SDG 14, New York

10-19 July 2017: High Level Political Forum review on “Eradicating poverty and promoting prosperity in a changing world” (SDGs 1, 2, 3, 5, 9, 14 and 17)

5-6 October 2017: Our Ocean conference, Malta

9-18 July 2018: High Level Political Forum review on "Transformation towards sustainable and resilient societies" (SDGs 6, 7, 11, 12, 15)

2018: Our Ocean conference, Indonesia

June-July 2019: High Level Political Forum review on “Empowering people and ensuring inclusiveness and equality” (SDGs 4, 8, 10, 13 and 17)

2019: Our Ocean conference, Norway

2019: First PROG Forum

July 2019: High Level Political Forum review of all SDGs

2020: UN Ocean Conference (under discussion)

Annex 3: Marine ecosystem-based management (EBM)

Marine EBM approaches are dynamic, adaptive, and iterative practices seeking to balance human wellbeing and ecosystem health in order to ensure the long-term sustainability of the ocean's ecosystem services. Definitions vary, though most apply at least five essential elements:

1. Approaching the ocean as holistic, interconnected ecosystems.
2. Incorporating a place-based context (environmental, governance, social, cultural, and historical) into management decision-making.
3. Managing for the cross-scale dynamics of ocean ecosystems (local to global geographies, short to long timeframes) with the need to effectively address transboundary governance within and across local, sub-national, national, regional, and global systems.
4. Accounting for the interconnections of ecological, social, economic, and governance aspects of ocean systems and the need to govern across sectors.
5. Incorporating diverse stakeholder perspectives and balancing conflicting objectives to develop an integrated approach to management.

Annex 4: Overview of selected regional ocean governance mechanisms

Type of ROG Mechanism	Description and potential contribution
Regional Seas Conventions and Action Plans	- RSCAPs work through Secretariats or Regional Coordinating Units (RCUs) that follow-up on the implementation of legal documents, programmes of work and policies adopted by the Contracting Parties. In some regions, Regional Activity Centers (RACs) are established with formal mandates and delegated authority from States to support the implementation of protocols or other thematic priorities. - RSCAPs will play a key role in coordinating actions related to SDG14 targets on pollution, conservation of marine living resources, and restoration of critical coastal and marine ecosystems and habitats.
Regional Fisheries Bodies	- The functions of RFBs can include the collection, analysis, and dissemination of information and data, coordinating fisheries management through joint schemes and mechanisms, serving as a technical and policy forum, and taking decisions relating to the conservation, management, development, and responsible use of the resources. - Many RFBs promote the ecosystem approach to fisheries and have huge potential to promote sustainable fisheries and aquaculture.
Regional Political and Economic Organisations	
The European Union	“International ocean governance: an agenda for the future of our oceans”²¹ is a central element of the EU’s response to the 2030 Agenda in particular Sustainable Development Goal 14 “to conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources”. Its objectives include improving the international ocean governance framework at global and regional level. - The Integrated Maritime Policy (IMP)²² provides the overarching framework for the EU’s ocean policy coordinating different sectors and actors through ‘horizontal and cross-cutting’ policy tools and initiatives to support transnational cooperation on commonly agreed maritime objectives. Under its auspices, regional sea strategies have been established to address

²¹ European Commission JOIN(2016) 49 final, ‘Joint Communication on International ocean governance: an agenda for the future of our oceans’ (10 November 2016).

²² COM(2007) 575 final and SEC(2007) 1278 on an Integrated Maritime Policy for the European Union.

	common challenges and opportunities vis-à-vis sustainable growth. • The Marine Strategy Framework Directive (MSFD)²³ articulates the regional approach as one of its underlying principles requiring the EU Members States to cooperate with other EU Members States and non-EU countries where appropriate on sea basin-level to coordinate the development of national marine strategies for implementation of the MSFD. Member States shall use existing regional institutional cooperation structures, including those under Regional Sea Conventions, respectively. • Under its Common Fisheries Policy (CFP)²⁴ regional cooperation on conservation measures is encouraged. In addition, advisory councils have been established to strengthen and coordinate stakeholder involvement for each sea basin/-region. • Marine Knowledge 2020²⁵ pools marine data from different sources on oceanography and human activities, both on the European as well as the sea basin level, to improve the knowledge base on oceans and seas, and help actors and stakeholders to make evidence-based and informed choices as well as decision-making.
African Union	• AIMS 2050 Strategy²⁶ proposes the development of a Common Fisheries Policy for the conservation, management, and exploitation of fish stocks for the Combined Exclusive Maritime Zone for Africa (CEMZA)(AIMS 2050 p.18) in line with the ecosystem-based management and precautionary approach. • NEPAD's Policy Framework and Reform Strategy for Fisheries and Aquaculture²⁷ promotes fisheries governance reforms to improve the productivity, profitability, and sustainability of fisheries and address IUU fishing. The Policy recommends cooperation and coordinated mechanisms among RECs, RFBs, and LME-based commissions to ensure coherence of fisheries policies and aquaculture at the regional level.
Leader-Driven Initiatives	

²³ EU Marine Strategy Framework Directive 2008/56/EC no **Fehler! Textmarke nicht definiert.**

²⁴ Regulation (EU) No 1380/2013.

²⁵ European Commission COM(2014) 254 final/2, 'Communication on Innovation in the Blue Economy: realising the potential of our seas and oceans for jobs and growth' (13 May 2014).

²⁶ African Union (2012).

²⁷ African Union, 'Policy Framework and Reform Strategy for Fisheries and Aquaculture in Africa' (10 September 2014). <https://au.int/web/sites/default/files/documents/30266-doc-au-ibar-fisheries-policy-framework-and-reform-strategy.pdf>.

The Micronesia Challenge	• The Micronesia Challenge (MC) is a commitment by the Federated States of Micronesia, the Republic of the Marshall Islands, the Republic of Palau, Guam, and the Commonwealth of the Northern Marianas Islands to preserve the natural resources that are crucial to the survival of Pacific traditions, cultures, and livelihoods. The overall goal of the Challenge is to effectively conserve at least 30% of the near-shore marine resources and 20% of the terrestrial resources across Micronesia by 2020.²⁸ • Micronesia Challenge (MC) has enabled remarkable transformations in marine and coastal management across the eight Micronesia Challenge jurisdictions. Over the course of 10–15 years, strategies to meet the MC have evolved to include: conservation action planning; the establishment of approximately 150 marine managed areas (MPAs); and the development and implementation of management plans for them; the local development, design, and launching of monitoring schemes for biophysical (marine and terrestrial), socioeconomic, and governance indicators; the development of a variety of fisheries policies; skills-building and coordination for local marine enforcement officers and task forces, such as the Alliance of Palau Conservation Officers; and the co-creation of local climate change adaptation toolkits, which are now being replicated across Micronesia, the Coral Triangle, and the Caribbean. • Micronesia sets an outstanding example of successful regional governance and solid capacity development partnership to support it – made possible, in part, through consistent leadership support, donor, and development investment and coordination, and capacity development over some 10–15 years.
The Coral Triangle Initiative on Coral Reefs, Fisheries and Food Security (CTI-CFF)	• The Coral Triangle Initiative on Coral Reefs, Fisheries, and Food Security (CTI-CFF) established in 2009 is a multilateral partnership of 6 countries²⁹ to address the urgent threats facing the coastal and marine resources of the Coral Triangle. Through the 10-year CTI-CFF Regional Plan of Action (CTI RPOA), the governments collaborate to strengthen the management of seascapes, promote an ecosystem approach to fisheries management (EAFM), improve management of marine protected areas (MPAs) and coastal community resilience and adaptation to climate change, and protect threatened species. • Among a host of achievements, the CTI-CFF has achieved, in policy and practice, from local to

²⁸ <http://www.themicronesiachallenge.blogspot.de/p/about.html>.

²⁹ Malaysia, Indonesia, Philippines, Papua New Guinea, Solomon Islands, Timor-Leste ('the CT-6').

	national to regional scales: - o Region-wide Early Action Plan for Climate Change Adaptation (REAP)³⁰ as well a Local Early Adaptation Plan toolkit implemented in each of the six countries, - o Regional EAFM Framework and national EAFM policies implemented, - o Coral Triangle System of MPAs and a common management effectiveness framework - o Transboundary IUU exercises to help successfully combat illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing, - o Ocean acidification monitoring framework and training among MPA and fisheries managers about the potential OA impacts to their coastal communities, and - o Permanent regional CTI-CFF Secretariat.
Caribbean Challenge Initiative	• The Caribbean Challenge Initiative (CCI) is a joint effort by governments, donors, businesses, and conservation organisations to build political support and generate long-term funding to protect the region's marine and coastal areas. Under the Initiative, the governments have committed to protect at least 20% of their near-shore marine/coastal environment by 2020, through comprehensive national systems of marine and coastal protected areas. • To enable participating countries to meet the Initiative's objectives, a Regional Biodiversity Fund has been established to provide a sustainable flow of funds for enforcement, infrastructure, and monitoring needs for the conservation and maintenance of biodiversity.
Pacific Oceanscape	• The Pacific Oceanscape Framework adopted at the 40th Pacific Islands Leaders Forum in 2009 is the region's implementation tool for the Pacific Islands Regional Ocean Policy and the Framework for Integrated Strategic Action (PIROF-ISA),³¹ the overarching framework for regional coordination, integration, and collaboration on ocean issues and coasts in the Pacific Island countries. • The Pacific Oceanscape emphasises integrated ocean management at all scales and has catalysed a number of developments to promote sustainable development, biodiversity conservation, establishment of marine protected areas, integrating traditional resource coastal management, and collaborative partnerships to manage resources in the high seas such as

³⁰ See Coral Triangle Initiative on Coral Reefs, Fisheries and Food Security, 'Region-wide Early Action Plan for Climate Change Adaptation for the Nearshore Marine and Coastal Environment (REAP-CCA)' (October 2011). http://www.coraltriangleinitiative.org/sites/default/files/resources/FINAL_CCA%20REAP_17Oct2011_Ig_V6.pdf.

³¹ The Pacific Islands Regional Ocean Policy and Framework for Integrated Strategic Action. <http://www.forumsec.org/resources/uploads/attachments/documents/pirop.pdf>.

	Pacific-ACP Regional Legislative and Regulatory Framework for Deep Sea Minerals Exploration and Exploitation.
Western Indian Ocean Coastal Challenge	The Western Indian Ocean Challenge (WIO-CC) is a partnership of WIO island and coastal countries and stakeholders, working together to achieve a range of commitments in international and regional agreements, projects and activities that address climate change, biodiversity conservation, desertification, and sustainable development over a 25 year period. The WIO-CC has great potential to leverage on the WIO countries to implement their Oceans 2030 Agenda commitments.